

twenty-five

Editor's Foreword

Despite the best efforts of myself, and the dedicated staff at Stanforth, Drake, and Macefield publishing house, the poetry presented here rarely achieves status above what can only be described as self-indulgent, self-centred slop. A state exacerbated by the poet's lack of ambition to reach beyond a quite limited talent to notice contemporary progress in poetics, let alone measure or dare I say, compete with it. There is an all-invasive self-deprecating ego without any redeeming humour, continuously coming last place at a first world trauma Olympics qualifying heat. This leaves a clear impression of an entirely contrived artist, as it simply cannot be possible to claim to be an outsider to something, when one is so dependent on the transcription of it. This is meagre millennial malaise dressed up as meaning, pointing at the absurd but saying nothing truthful or of substance in the manner of a toddler pointing at a dog in a shopping centre. Pattern recognition, at best, mistaken for insight; at worst, mistaken epiphany. Assemblage masquerading as architecture confusing depth for depth itself. Here, we see a poet who has lost their purpose. I fear, the readers opening this book will only be reminded of the things they would most like to forget, or at least gain respite from the very reason they began to consider poetry as a solution to their problems in the first place. A stark reminder of what can be achieved by petty bourgeoisie dilettante who's moral and political compass I suspect rarely elevates beyond *needs must*. This is a poet without sense of direction, seemingly incapable of developing over time. Aware, that the world's attention has become more bite-sized; The *poet* in response, has become more carouselled in the work's blurring; an illusion he hopes we mistake for truth. Which really, is only a realisation that he is becoming

the most boring type of western men, The AutoDidact Didact.

I conclude, with deepest regret, to my future reputation as editor and publisher that this collection exists and for any time any readers may spend on it.

However, despite these inherent debts of talent, intellect, and craft amidst a world seeking to undermine the integrity and freedom of human creativity, I find the poet's determination, indeed insistence, to record the experience of their life in poetry, not only an admirable resistance, but an entirely necessary one.

Sincerely

Ada Blotzheim-Thomas
Principal Editor

Lashes

o those days we spent half duvet
half settee rarely dressed
in-between the quiet joy-
scrolling pre-algo internet

when you'd notice a loose lash
that just needed to be pulled
right there and then - plucked
from the boredom that turned
you to me - chipped teal and pink
fingernails trace blunt chisel
crook of my broken nose
crowning the ridge of the watershed
where my tears might flow

glittered chub thumb peels back
eyelid in a soft give then swift
and sharp it breaks it pops!

I see you
in watered blur
hold the hair to the light
like a jeweller

what do you see in your loupe eye, my love?
how far back does that story go?
sand toothed nomads in the Caucasus?
mill managers in shirt garters
under green lamps calculating smog?
overalls top-turning nursery soil?
or the pickups of builder's dust?

all grown long enough to guard
to fight and protect their craft

these days I feel the lashes growing awkward
and very soon, will be against us

Ibrahim & I

I was on the train back North
when a Senegalese man I mistook for a Rasta
tried to convert me to Islam
between Kings Cross and Peterborough

Good ol' Ibrahim, we smiled in our chat
you rendering Joseph to Yusuf - *he who adds
who builds*, is universal in any language.
You tell me not to waste life

because the day will come, when fire
pours through all seven holes
it's grand unified sermon wrapping it all up
into a simple song, that cannot be undone

painless in the light of your Allah, or not
at all if it's hidden from the big pot
that mixes it all up. The colours of us
I think I got that bit right, right Ibrahim?

the truth you say can only be revealed
when we begin to write right to left
but that's not the same as backwards
Ibrahim, am I getting it? As the platform became

unplanted clay baking in the Sun
then fields sprayed with crystal bright pesticide
I hear you in my reflection - *our body is just
a dress for a soul, forever prepared for death*

Morning Poem 21602c26-a084-45df-903e-
8d162dab4a8a

fog's unbroken silence hangs Sladen Bridge
as sharp clap lifts grouse from slumbered heather
mixing with the coming day, going about the ruins
of farmhouses and glass fitted barn conversions
like a milkman on his rounds - fresh mornings
the tourists can never know; if only the timetables
and guides could describe Cemetery Road
under the last of the sulphur lampposts
yellow as old Cow bones, waiting for the dogs

an enduring resistance in refusing to say sorry
refusal to renounce what is necessary to do
regardless of the postcard racks, their content
content and tat's excess of blessings containing
no lessons on the actual moments we can enjoy

or even the most extreme deprivations
that stands in the same queues, forgoes
the carriage of bitterness, safe in the knowledge
that our lives are not merely decided by image

as fog fills the days, that so often weakens
in the double-shelled reservoir and sky
when meeting a long-known face, breaks
from heavy silence, into sudden, unforced laughter

Night Poem No. ∞

skin stuck sheets
air drags its closeness
too slow for comfort
 too slow
 too close

to give oneself over to it

smooth dark sieves
 thumping heart

losing what you never had
 is a cruel double grief

and it's all keeping me awake

night trembles fox-steps
rain splashed puddles
tip-toe lace petticoats
diesel milkman pickup

how to receive
 and respond
 how to receive what you have
 no power over
how to give oneself
 over to it all
 and fall into sleep

and to wake up again

Playing Tetris

a day when
thoughts tumble
like Tetris blocks

a fall
a turn
a search for fit

as the gaps
between thumb
and screen

stack up
longing for
disappearance

next door's semi-detached
stone clefts caught
mid-fall in the rendering

are they dropping
or turning
or searching

or the part of the wall
that makes the house
a home

I see Tetris everywhere now
you will always be
my personal best

in this counting
this turning and searching
and falling

do we stop ourselves
from ever actually winning
but even here

even now
in this most private
of places

a poem
or the gap
between thumb and screen

I cannot speak clearly
to say exactly
what I mean

to tell you how I feel
in all this turning
and searching

and falling
and longing
and disappearing

All Lent, No Easter.

voyeurs, because there's not much else to do

capturing without intention observation creates

from what is being observed tabs of the
screenshare

stack a sacred geometry I am reminded

of your set of Matryoska dolls of Vladimir Putin

in a nun's habit when the doctor examines

the x-ray of my chest fluffy labyrinth

that curves its reflection backwards to the doctor's eye

translation of time passing in light in decades

in years months weeks goodbyes

these days i'm considering the ways we build the things

that build themselves inside themselves and how

we can still succeed if systems fail scapegoats abound

mewshouting behind luxury avatars

veiled in some other grace some other type

superduperficial trivia clicks to what really matters

that there is always plenty on the table
for everyone to eat

but what isn't clear to me
is whether the present is being broken
by the past or the future

Decathect

flag stone shored lapping it up as steeled LNER
passes like a living room with the big light on
around the blinking red lit Totnes Nuclear Station
where curved shadows fall in mottled blue

and eyelids supple protection flexes knuckled pink
that couldn't be pink but as if it was black
and black was all fireworks

it hinges on knowledge breeched
by motives weakened in impulse
reflective, hardly ever considered

o soft egg-eyed duvet mornings mouthfuls of lace
crashing awake in these great big bags of blood
heavy as a body, as an honest day's work

waiting for a reply to a sentence in a conversation
you've been having your whole shabby life

as replays of harsh words fix themselves in tingly
decisions

 quiver tremulous link yearns resonance
after-imaging regret's falling seconds that repeat
on you like an afternoon of bad sandwiches

what poverty of language we bear when describing
love
the lonely lament of Love's passing - to explain
ourselves
or the ways we cannot bear reality, how it smooths
itself

these phones are a curse on us all

again, honey-bee, again!
let's go ice skating
round oncle Arthur's
house!

the ice is waiting for us
o where have you gone, my darling one?

and why were we chosen
to be left behind?

Ten Miles A Day, Every Day

it's a well-known fact
at least, to some of us, anyway
that a loyal dog needn't be chained
to stay by their home and master
and for a dog to be this loyal
it need only be well loved
a fact, an obvious truth perhaps,
known well to those who have kept
such things close to them

so, when I'm out walking, and hear
a familiar echo making its way over the valley.
A dog's yelp. jumping all over the place, chained
to its sound. Barking at something unknown
What is it lad? Threat or salvation, what
is it boy? Hard to reckon from this range,
everything compresses in an echo, slamming
distance with emotion, with hardness
so that only this yelp is heard,
only the yelp remains;
it runs right up your neck
and around and away until nowt is left
the way a dog's tongue can lick a bowl clean.

It is well known in these parts, that a loyal dog
needn't be chained; perhaps this is the thing
that the dog means to say, what its yelp
is desperate to tell us. But it's too far off
for us to tell, too far off to do owt about it
and too nice a day to worry ourselves especially

Subject: Concerns Meeting

Dear Colleague

we regret to inform you that your recent personal problems have broken the code of conduct as agreed within your terms of employment

see attached flowchart

note: the scaffolding metaphor used by your line manager has been denied approval by the Department of metaphorical liability and any solace or personal growth caused by the metaphor should be struck from the record

the reasons cited was the sudden, forced tropes around scaffolding and emotional crises

be the man you actually are

has been flagged for review due to possible infraction of Authenticity Safeguarding requirement 28.1.b

next steps:

complete and return the attached impact assessment within 6 hours of this e-mail been sent

we look forward to you joining our next Joy In The Workplace seminar next Tuesday and the following networking drinks

Kind Regards

The Human Oversight Team
Digital Wellness Dept
Ministry Of Divination
The New World Order

Windcutter

in avoiding embarrassment
we will discover whole new ways
of embarrassing ourselves
we could never have imagined

o washcloth grey skies zipping
up fold-a-way macs for that
prospect of warm summer rain

with slightest delay, it revisits
by the round pond, slotted
between earth and sky
as coins in pockets once did

wisped clouds watermark
Britannia's shield and monarch
face-in-profile, organza thin
disappears in the conquer
of dewfall's cold indexing

chequered octagons milieu lily-pads
and the little ladders
to the little duck house

as water laminars weir

pours flatness
into flatness

these places we keep to recall
past joys remarkably conceived

these places we keep to forget

the times we rewind for ourselves

the time we wished

we had never said

what we actually felt

nine-nine-six - up to tricks

very complex games of linguistics extending in all
directions
from places of purposeful quiet, places of loving grace

voleur-de-vie

but, in a sloppy world that doesn't need more
why are we asking mirrors to invent light?

emotionally intentional

and so, we're working and learning ways of working,
we did this/did that, until we found ourselves capable of
doing it

making urgent meaning

and money isn't much of an issue
as we've learnt it makes no difference in making us
happy -

quite the opposite

when squandered youth has no value it's difficult to tell
if it's better to burn out or fade away but either is better
than

grinding yourself

until we are unsure what is left - to love, and even to give
love
dovetailed commitment - that mutual growth and security

(unplanned rebellions)

that fills above the brim of self, the feeling of ourself

and even perhaps to be able to receive such things in
return

superior calling

to a story above self-dreamt myths a possibility to go
beyond
survival beyond timid existence - fleetingly

fragile beauty

to be truly present when love flows then you just might
be able to have it all and enjoy the many years of joy to
come

Whilst Considering An Autism Disclosure To An Employer,
I Think About You And Never Feeling Like I Had To Perform

clinging to fears of the unknown
is one of the easiest ways
to miss out on a well lived life

when disconnected when the next feels too much
too exhausting to consider

more than the walls we felt necessary to build

time doesn't pass like it used to

and in the evenings passing the time with actors
indulged in misfortune of others call it homework

the small victories that keep you going

these moods mimicking vibes
hopeful of acceptance
these wonders of life

birdsong as music favourite food, done the right way

hidden worlds node hushed secret comforts

like that certain person that lets you feel
that certain way - days flow thru
dust caught shafts - that certain warmth
to be that little bit more alive
that certain feeling of yourself
as waves of them collect
during evening's quiet introspect

a brush through hair
puffed cheeks smiling
bug crossed eyes

acknowledging the struggle but not drowning in it

keeping the list of people
who might attend your funeral
longer than your shopping list

listening out
until you hear a slow repeat
of an ambient prayer

that place
summoning actor's state
sat in the bare bulb dressing room

rehearsing our lines

readying our best masks for the audience

without realising
without considering

what such a weight could mean
to the deep hunger of purpose
of peace

understudies to ourselves

in the shows we create we act
to make sense
to provide security, safety
in desperate acts of making connections
fearful
of what they always seem to cost

no-one should be considered a form

of missing out

you and i,

will be the main event of our lives

when we choose to grasp it

nobody should be afraid

of missing life

unless you live a total lie

in a fixated revision

of your interior self

Prayer To The Future

grant us the systems we need
to expand the labour of our devotion
to an ultra-abundance
of timely salvation

grant us frames of reference
that will be ours and only ours
frames of references that create
echoes amen echoes amen

grant us the serenity to exercise
our perfectly bound ignorance
in perfectly utilised structures
echoes amen echoes amen

and give us the courage to restructure
what will maximise our self interest
and wisdom to know the difference
amen echoes amen

The More I Write, The More Obnoxious It Gets

where the search for it settles
the place of the spectacle will move
you've never seen it, only where it just was
it wants you to think of shadows, dancing
or a smoking gun, like... red-handed
but that's playing right into its trick
making you think you can know the trace of it
but it's tapped you on the left shoulder
and side-stepped to the right - it's better to visualise
a hall of mirrors filled with disco balls and dancing
it's better to go in there and not worry about it all
as power is much of a muchness
we realise to ourselves in the Tesco aisles
that acquisition of resources is as natural
as militant revolutionary praxis

saying that
relative to context
how we exist in parallax
to stories not relationally held
to the trauma that identifies us
to what defines
realising the power to overcome
problems
sceptics earn their living repeating

good versus evil
feels like choreographed wrestling
poor triumphing wealth's tyranny
righteous over immoral

us and the otherness

these ways we cherish our disappointment

turning to anger

then resignation to playful irony

cynically sweet

when righteous art vessels impassivity

serving function

as one might be served

drinks in a beach resort

Lost And Found

yeah sure, I've had a broken heart, I guess
who hasn't, but maybe that's what we go
looking for as regret doesn't prevent repeats

it's just the sort of thing that can happen
when we are asked to be loved, I guess
now don't get me wrong, I like love, sure

maybe as much as the next person
but it gets so tough to keep trusting the answers
we find, the actions that we feel

what an awful business it all is
always trying to be our best self
and how it's all meant to be

balanced
between perfectly polite
and not boring them to tears

kinda like being on a see-saw, I guess
you either get a mouthful of bark chips
or a full eyed sky and a bump on the head

or maybe it's more like a pet shelter, I guess
browsing amongst the cages, puppy eyes, burning
unaware nobody can fall in love with sadness

or maybe we're all in the cages, begging
to be taken home and washed and fed
sated, before falling asleep in front of a fire

or maybe it's more like a Lost & Found office
you know the one, with the cheery porter
indexing all that heavy baggage in neat order

waiting for someone to turn up and give a description
of every attribute, every flaw, give it a name, give every
reason
as to why it's so important, the very why they want it

the very why they need it this very moment,
how long they have travelled for it, searched for it
until the porter hands it over, certain, no-one is
guessing.

Childhood Poem No. Umpteenbillion

phones purr haptic
squirming seeds
playing nervous on knees

by the mower sheds
childhood seemed forever
and we couldn't wait

for it all to end
the dull purr
we longed for it

and on it goes
until soft vibrations
becomes a digging

there there oh dear
what could it be
flushed in close heat

until we are all
dug out by it
so, let's really listen

hopefully we can
find some answer
to its meaning

and what was it
you needed
fetching from the shops

but couldn't find

the right words
to spare - the strength

to ask again - or
again, to repeat
oneself is wearisome

in well dressed
and well mannered
bungalows - pushing

hobbies around
cabbaged
in two tone slippers

as morning gathers mist
above the Methodist
Chapel's pediment

building with the motion
of a sad routine
where our best efforts lie

in well-meaning smiles
in tender thoughted meals
in doing alright for ourselves

do we create something
to fear or behold
becoming too much

of ourselves
of a character
in a story

we never wanted to write

Valley Poem - 1499e61c-679d-4e4c-9820-
2c8a2204c47b

fields slope under white mist
the very best green dress
laid out on the bedsheets

and they start to dance!

slow you know like that
God
what a privilege to watch it all

how it changes
just a little each day

we barely notice their passing

how it changes

how their hands and feet

curl and weld
like centuries

taking you each time

fingertips behind an ear

and whispers

come to bed, Love

*we've to get up early tomorrow
and do it all over again*

Crabtree At The Bumble Date

was a blazer too much, or is it too late to worry?
Crabtree wishes he'd practised conversation more
or interstellartelekinesis, so he could crash a meteor
right through this god forsaken Slug and Lettuce

Crabtree looks down at a pint of craft beer
and wonders why we've made something so good,
so unpalatable - who is trying to prove, which point?

perhaps self-fulfilment will come
when personal brand and identity aligns
with craft beer. Crabtree reaches for the glass

clutching fingers around the waist of its tulip shape.
to hold it, for it to mean something, even
to go in the search for it, seems like reaching

out and expecting to be kissed and held
like the World Cup to a cheering crowd
before falling like dead birds through clouds.

maybe a fastener and a quick vape will help
Mercury Rising the curled up foil sticker reveals
the product's flavour and a flick of the wrist

reveals no new notifications on the iWatch.
but best check the phone too, just in case
their messages have yet to come through.

The Burden Of Love

to think the universe could have made you
cooked up in a tiny nook of the infinite unseen
what a supernova that must have been

in my teens; I saw in a charity shop window
a wicker basket outdoor picnic set, tastefully
covered in motif of Japanese birds over flowers
and thinking how perfect things could be
and thinking what a perfect gift it would be
for you and only you, if only, we'd have met

late twenties; our most powerful accident
sat together always, getting lost in channels
fingernails, hair, tattoos, your voice, my favourite
program I always tuned in - delicate alliance
of burnt mahogany eyes, warm sting touch
all we ever wanted was everything

thirties; we realise the birds do not sing
for us, we've planned the living room together
I watch you, smoking in the bath, as I shave
in a broken mirror, neither of us having to ever
prove anything with a smile

forties; watching deadened memories
of supple bodies and both of us settling
for what we've always wanted
as life is who we make plans with

fifties; we will write our best poems
if youth is all about chasing pleasure
now it's a matter of relieving pain
our hopes are sown into the garden
I make you breakfast each morning

sixties; knackered eyes from din lit hours

rusting coins at the bottom of a wishing well
but what can I say, to you, my love.
the life expectancy of a northern male is just this.
you will live a long and happy life
without the burden of love.

twenty-five

there's a place we should make
plans to attend
together in our best clothes
well rested in our smiles
i'll meet you there
but first
you must find this place
and understanding
that you get there by believing
in the future and ourselves
as being the only option
now step outside
and take the path
through the white picket gate
along the cricket field's boundary
past the visiting circus hot pink big top
hang a straight up and out
until the bluejay's song
becomes like a kettle on a stove
when someone you know
has taken it off the whistle
to make tea that will cool your nerves
keep going
until the long rows of the felt tulip farm
sharpen into view
next to the regional mason's lodge
where men with funny handshakes
meet under battenberg lanthorn
ask them which way to go
and do the exact opposite
unless it's a Tuesday or the month
of ##### and sure enough
you'll come across a meadow
of crestless gold slowly lifting
to sunlit uplands called destiny
but go right past that

as it's just an immersive advert
for a cash-n-carry
it's a couple of kicks and several clicks
until you come to a restoration
of a Pyongyang Cigarette Machine Museum
its dull steel and vegetable dye labels
lure you in by design; grab the door handle
but wait for a conjunction of mars and jupiter
and a thrice owned white transit van
that pulls over and offers you a lift
turn it down at the same time as the handle
and you'll find yourself in a corridor
of ancient bureaucracy - fax machines
regurgitate hieroglyphics of birds singing
in the ashes of a scorched forest
don't get sidetracked by the minutiae
of suffering, walk past it all
until you find the door with that name
etched in gold on the shuttered glass pane
you'll know it's the right door by the name
you'll just know - knock five times
and the door behind you will be opened
by a person whose entire skin
has been covered by five-inch honeycomb
tattoos in Edwardian Sailors ink
do not bring attention but treat them
as you do with all people
by looking at them in the eye
and bringing them the gift of your smile
they will ask you if you are ready
to confront the reality of your art
and its impact on the world
the answer you give
will not make a difference
the honeycombed person will guide you
into an oak paneled room
they will take you to a balcony overlooking
the traced perambulations of Earth's orbit
over the last billion years in a five second loop

frozen stiff with fear
they will push you over the railing bar
and dangle you by the ankles
until all your blood rushes around
at the rate of a pressure washer
licking moss off a driveway
until all the consequences of your past
seem as relevant as all
the different things we could have
and all the nice things
we couldn't be trusted with
until someone else is waiting
for the same tour, don't worry
they will pull you right back over
hand you a slice of their mother's
famous rhubarb cheesecake
and deposit you into a laundry chute
that falls for several minutes
in complete erasure of time
of person
until you land on green asphalt
like a gymnast
and the onlooking valets in red waistcoats
will hold up scores out of ten
wait in the porte cochere
until all the valets have judged
so they can understand
which borderline MOT Pass Jaguar to bring out
check the mirror panel for your leather gloves
and the glove box for the tin of boiled sweets
pull the gloves back until your knuckles
are as tight inside the glove as a leather catsuit
place a boiled sweet under your tongue
rev the engine into the hard red
then slam it into first
if you time it just right
the Jaguar will soar like Pegasus
if not you will break the Jaguar
and the valets will bring you another

and another and another
until you get it just so
don't be disparaged
it took me a decade
to get that thing in the air
but once you do the heaviness
becomes a slow peaceful stillness
as you canter down a steep highway
of supermagnified black
flanked with iron trellis
of rainbow-stained climbing roses
before the approaching mid-distance
surfaces a Burger King sign
on the service station walkway
park in a marked EV charging bay
and halfway across the walkway
set a pinhole camera
on the motorway below
until you've captured the perfect callotype
of a fallen angel drinking Vimto
from a leaf-tailed chalice
take the print and zoom in
on the chalice's MADE IN CHINA stamp
to find a map that shows
the sources and mouths of all rivers
that will look to you like nerves
thrown in patterns on a screen
but pay no attention to show-offs
except of course
me
as within the springs and branches
within the confluences and waterfalls
the weirs and rapids and silt banks
you will notice a familiarity
that you cannot ignore
kindred to how the movements of water
have created such transmigrations
of dirt and rock and core
that you will leap from the overpass

and become submerged in a puddle
streaked with all the colours of a crayon box
reflected from the Burger King sign above
use all of the spectrum to wash
off the grit from your palms and knees
turn seventy-three degrees to your left
and you'll see in a convex traffic mirror
rotating tanks of an Ourobus nursery
tended by a squad of small children
in yellow haz mat suits
against a purple dusted chimney stacked skyline
this is a good sign
a sign
that you are close to it
to this place of precise vigour
of loving security
we all look forward to on the way home
that's all bonkers in the right direction
that's unheeded by fear of saying
the wrong thing at the wrong time
to the right person that brings you joy
when life is an endless ladder
when we move beads across the saunpan
to check if we've more days left
than we've had
to go to those who are not afraid
of the daily routines of love
one of the gardeners will remove a glove
and hand you a business card
with a single hanzi character
that you cannot possibly know symbolises
fox
but in the slope of its radical
that timid howling beauty
you will see a symmetrical QR code
scan it with an update required phone
and in due course a hackney cab will arrive
when the driver asks *where to?*
you will quote blade runner

scenes from Macbeth and several
undocumented speeches from JFK
and they will respond they don't go
sarf of the river at this time of day
but will make an exception as they
were impressed with your recall
of his favourite film and president
which is really just an opening gambit
for the driver to plug his self-published book
'how to escape by not escaping'
when a copy drops through the perspex hatch
you make out a gold labelled blurb
cruelty for cruelties sake
from a respected literary professor
you once corresponded with
The cab will stop
outside *The Lion And Fox*
tell him to keep the change
as you enter the pub you'll find it's happy hour
and the fish wived voice of a forgotten Thames
fights feedback of a karaoke machine
buy a lemonade and wait for the woman
to come with the bag of illicit candles
pick - Carbolic Soap
take this to a toilet cubicle
and light it
until those clean thick vapours
release suppressed memories
of ancient solar oscillations
and the trauma
of having to carry a fully grown man
around on your back all this time
until they were suitably housetrained
and no longer a block in your calendar
stay until the muffled noise of the pub
becomes like the image
of a bow echo on a radar
this will help you pinpoint the location
of the baker's daughter

who sits all night eating the gingerbread
ghosts of her father's victims
bring her milk
speak with her
and listen to her simple philosophy
of long back breaking work to pass time
as been key to a happy family
when she has finished follow her
through her father's meagre kitchens
their clean swept floors and kettle click silence
through back-fanged gardens linking
to savannahd alleys
of night lurking tom-cats
measure the distance of each stride
in quarter notes
in cross-stitch
as allotment carrots glow
under strawberry fizz moon
until you come to a viewing platform
on a hire-by-the-hour cherry picker
and the baker's daughter turns
in her gingham pinafore
and points across the canyon
dropping below and away
beyond your vision
and with the other finger
draws it vertical over her lips
in that universal sign of *hush*
lightning spreads like Kintsugi on a plate
in a split second
you've become witness
to an emerging economy's
latest thermobarric bomb test
it's growing mushroom of sound
comes at you like a tsunami
a complete alabaster firmament
lifts your ankles to tiptoe
and carries you off on a breeze
like a condor taking flight you will glide

over the deep treeless ravines
over toy-town suburbs of people
scrolling past genocides
over quantum data centres
and betweenness of boarding houses
and corrugated tin roof allotments
and queueful friday fishoils
and rooftops of sticky pigeon coops
toiling in anthracite night
of a long forgotten
long since imagined culture
held by the neck in a mother's jaw
you will be dropped like a kitten
to a white linen covered table
set with a nine-piece silver tea service
pretty as a summer's polka dot dress
against cloth thick botanical print wallpaper
which at both times gives the air and feel
of a steel barrier on a mountain road
garlanded with cellophane wrapped flowers
or a breath filled sheet fort
torchlit between grassed knees
as we compare our days capture
in the killing jars
when all is good and all is well
when everything lines up
i will join you
qualmed in ever quickening heartbeats
skin cold under flushing
as i watch you tuck hair behind your ear
and we will describe confessions
of our wanted addictions
wondering how we will ever get back here
and have this together again
and more
and again
and forever

